also knew their money was going to a good cause. Even though I was injured and might have had the time to help for once, Victoria took charge of everything. She's got a gift for it: how things should look, when things should happen, what's there for people to enjoy. And she pays attention to the last detail.

I only got home from Manchester the evening before and so things were a bit of a rush. There was time, though, for one present. I gave Tony a watch to say thank you for all the work he'd done in negotiating the contract I'd signed at Old Trafford 24 hours earlier. That turned into quite an emotional scene in our kitchen in the middle of the Sunday afternoon. And at the same time, of course, we had our families, our kids and their kids, running backwards and forwards in amongst the last-minute arrangements for the party and our bags, half-packed for Dubai the following day.

Eventually we were dressed and ready. We had photos taken—more money for the charity—and then headed towards the marquee where it was all happening, up behind the house. To get there, you had to walk through our little plot of forest which has a kind of Japanese feel to it anyway. We'd taken that as the theme for the whole party. Except for the bouncy castle: lots of the players had brought their children along and so we had one blown up for them next to the grown-ups' tent. Brooklyn walked alongside me. We had matching outfits: a knee-length Japanese-style jacket over the trousers, with a red sash around the waist. I don't know about me but my boy looked very cute indeed. And we wore flip flops because my left foot still wasn't comfortable in a shoe at that point. It was all going on in my garden but, because Victoria had thought it all out, I felt like one of the 400 guests. I couldn't wait to see what she had waiting for us up through the woods.

Lanterns were lit all the way through the garden. There were gymnasts and acrobats spinning around the flower beds and between the trees. There were dancers, martial arts experts. Surprises everywhere. Mis-Teeq sang, the R&B singer Beverley Knight, too, and Russell Watson, the opera singer. The marquee where dinner was served was really two connecting marquees. The first had been decorated like an oriental garden. There were thousands of orchids that had been flown in from Japan and Indonesia, and a little bridge, with carp swimming in a pool underneath, which you had to climb across to reach the main tent just beyond it. You walked through huge curtains hung at either side. There were geisha girls welcoming people. And then the tables, all beautifully laid out—Victoria had decided on everything down to the napkins and cutlery—stretched away in front of you. It was all red, black and white: one of the most beautiful settings I've ever seen in my life.